



Investigating INKJETS

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Agent 001 trolls the market for printers under Rs 5,000

While we undercover agents lead a flashy lifestyle—money, women, gadgets, the works—some of our jobs, like printing assignment reports are pretty routine. I decided to head down the hardware highway and track an inexpensive, decent quality inkjet around. I set my budget at Rs 5,000 and I was determined not to pay a paisa more!

I located a few select dealers of specific brands. Brands like Lexmark were hard to find, though their Z12 printer is fairly popular. It is touted as one of the cheapest inkjets that you can buy off the shelf, but beware! Dealers will try to convince you that this printer really does cost as low as Rs 3,000. The catch is that it comes with only a black ink cartridge and the colour cartridge will set you back by another Rs 1,500. So you end up paying around Rs 4,500! Some system integrators will also bundle this printer along with the system that you are purchasing—just ensure he bundles both the cartridges.

At Lamington road, Mumbai, I expected some frank opinions on an inexpensive, good quality inkjet printer. So I asked the

first dealer what he could offer me for under Rs 5,000. His advice: “Opt for the Canon BJC 2100SP. It comes with both the cartridges installed as default, and at Rs 4,200 it’s pretty inexpensive.” This printer comes with parallel and USB interfaces, which is an added benefit, and also has an optional scanner cartridge that would allow you to scan full colour images at 360 dpi. The brochure he gave me stated that the printer could do 5 ppm (pages per minute) in monochrome.

On further investigation, I found that the printer comes with no ‘Power-on’ switch, which basically means it runs directly off the mains. Though this is not a major problem, it made me a little uncomfortable about it.

My next stop was at an exclusive Epson dealer. He quoted that the Epson C20SX was a hot favourite in the market. It retailed for Rs 4,600, which did fit my budget. What the dealer did not tell me was that this printer is notorious for a rather peculiar problem—you can change cartridges only through a software; try to do it manually and the cartridges will be rendered useless! Also the process takes long.

Trudging on, I landed at a retail shop selling all popular brands. I also spotted Sharp AJ-1100 printer. The price was a little out of my range at Rs 6,000 and had a single four-colour cartridge. Other high-end HP models included the HP DJ845c (Rs 8,000) and the HP DJ920c

Consumables: Find out the price of the cartridges much in advance. High operation costs can hurt in the long run.
Quality: Photo-quality inkjets generally print at about half the speed of your average inkjets and have high operation cost. If you don’t plan to print too many images, opt for a regular inkjet.
Resolution: Take the dpi (dots per inch) specifications claimed by most manufacturers with a pinch of salt. The best way to evaluate print quality is to compare actual printouts.
Speed: Manufacturers list print speed in pages per minute (ppm). These are usually measured at low-quality ‘draft’ settings using very simple text pages and can be unrealistic under normal use.
Interface: A printer that uses a USB port is usually much faster than the old-fashioned parallel port models.

(Rs 10,500)—superb quality but beyond my budget!

Then I found an exclusive HP dealer. There I learned that the ever-popular DJ640c was on its way out, and their new kid on the block was the DJ656c (HP updates models every few months or so). This printer retails at Rs 5,000, but with a little haggling you could get it for under Rs 5,000. It is a pretty neat printer—the brochure screams a duty cycle of 1000 pages per month with 512 KB of built-in RAM and USB connectivity. The print quality was pretty good too. The brochure claims a maximum of 600x300 dpi on photo quality paper.

The older DJ640c too retails for about Rs 5,000 odd, is parallel port driven and has similar specifications. “You can find HP printer service centers anywhere you go and you shouldn’t have any trouble getting your printer serviced”. This is where other printer brands fall short. HP’s cartridges are also fairly inexpensive and easily available.

Sadly, the market is full of fake printer cartridges that could ruin your printer, so always go to an authorised service centre for spares or help.

Also, make sure you don’t get conned into purchasing those ‘printer + scanner’ combinations. You will generally end up buying older, or phased out products with no real cost benefit. Just do a little hunting and you will end up beating the combination price! ■



Pentium 4 processor

Looking for a cheap P4-based system? 1.6 GHz P4 (Northwood) with 512 KB cache is going for as low as Rs 9,000.